TEACHER NOTES · GRADES 4–8

Talking with students about vaping & tobacco

These notes pair with AVA's two student handouts, one for grades 4–6 and one for grades 7–8. Short conversations repeated through the year work better than a one-time talk.

Three messages to land

1

Most kids don't vape.

Lead with the healthy norm: about 95% of middle and high schoolers don't.

2

Nicotine is addictive.

Growing brains get hooked faster, and quitting is hard.

3

You can choose, and ask for help.

Practice saying no, and name the trusted adults to go to.

Before you start

- Check your district's health curriculum and tobacco policy.
- Let the school counselor know the topic is coming up.
- Set ground rules: no names, no stories about others, anyone can pass.
- Offer an anonymous question box for questions students won't ask aloud.
- Some students live with adults who smoke or vape. Talk about products and choices, never "bad people."

What works, what backfires

WORKS

Discussion and role-play

The healthy norm: most kids don't vape

Media literacy: who profits?

Short, repeated check-ins

BACKFIRES

Scare tactics and graphic images

Showing real devices or brand names

"Everyone's doing it" messages

Lecturing or singling students out

Turn over for grade-level guidance and tough moments →

Tailoring it by grade

Grades 4–6

- What a vape is, and why nicotine harms growing bodies
- How candy flavors and bright colors trick us
- Simple ways to say no
- Naming their trusted grown-ups

TRY THIS

Say-no practice. In pairs, one student offers, the other uses a line from the handout. Then switch.

Grades 7–8

- How nicotine addiction works, and why quitting is hard
- Marketing, influencers and social media
- Nicotine pouches and “nicotine-free” myths
- Handling pressure and helping a friend

TRY THIS

Myth or fact? Small groups sort the handout’s myths, then defend each answer with evidence.

Handling tough moments

“I vape.”

Stay calm and thank them for trusting you. Follow your school’s protocol and connect them with the counselor.

“My dad vapes.”

Reassure them it isn’t their fault and nicotine is hard to quit. Keep the focus on their own choices.

A question you can’t answer

“Great question. Let me find out.” Then follow up next class.

Free resources

CATCH My Breath

Vaping prevention lessons, free to U.S. schools, grades 5–12

catch.org

Quit help for students 13+

Text DITCHVAPE to 88709 (This is Quitting, Truth Initiative)

Stanford Tobacco Prevention Toolkit

Free lessons for elementary, middle and high school

med.stanford.edu/tobaccopreventiontoolkit

Invite AVA student leaders

Email to request a classroom visit

info@antivapealliance.org